

She hardly had time to take pictures of the buildings she loved, much less get to know them.

About a year ago several things happened at once. First, she started to get threatening phone calls. She told the security people at work about the calls but they could do nothing. The calls kept coming, and each time the voices seemed more desperate. Next, she collected a big block of company stock options. For the first time in her life, Maggie enjoyed a substantial net worth. Finally, an architectural magazine asked her to contribute some articles on nineteenth-century English country homes.

Maggie retired. The last time I saw her she had been traveling continuously for about a year, studying buildings and taking pictures. She was preparing for a Chicago trade show where she could show her work. She was still hyper but not high-powered. She confessed to me that, in her darkest self, she feels she wouldn't be alive today if she had kept her job.

Maggie is somewhat curious because she refuses to control her expenses. She retired with about \$500,000, mostly in stocks. Instead of buying CDs in 1985, like I suggested, she put her money in the stock market. The stocks proceeded to double and triple in value. Maggie could be a millionaire by now, but she spends lavishly. She travels first-class. She goes to expense-account restaurants without an expense account. She has a big heart and in her first retired year probably gave away a third of her net worth.

I offered to help her prepare a budget, but she's too busy to budget. She may run out of money one day. On the other hand, with her luck in the stock market she may wind up buying a couple of those nineteenth-century English country homes she loves.

The last retirement-timing story is my own. The notion of retiring popped up in my two-year test when I was 33. Vicki and I started working through the idea and became convinced